Bonus Guide 1 of 5

THE POTTERY TEMPLATE VAULT

Decorating Techniques Guide

Stamps, sponges, carving, sgraffito & slip techniques for handbuilt pottery

Decorating Techniques Guide

> Your templates give you consistent, accurate shapes. This guide shows you what to do with the surface once the piece is built — before and after bisque firing.

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1 · Clay States and Timing

State	Description	Best for
Soft (plastic)	Clay just rolled out, still flexible	Stamps, rollers, press textures, deep impressions
Leather-hard	Firm, cool to the touch, holds its shape without support	Carving, sgraffito, slip application, attaching handles
Bone-dry	Dry and fragile, no moisture left	Light sanding only — no wet techniques; avoid sharp impacts
Bisqueware	First firing done (approx. 950–1000 °C), porous and strong	Underglazes, oxides, brush painting, wax resist

⭐ **Important**

The most common mistake is trying to carve too early (clay too soft) or too late (bone-dry). Leather-hard is the sweet spot for most surface work.

2 · Tools You Will Need

- **Loop and ribbon tools** — carving and removing clay

- **Sgraffito tools / needle tool** — fine line work
- **Natural sponges** — texture and blending
- **Rubber and foam stamps** — repeated patterns
- **Rollers with texture mats** — full-slab texturing
- **Fan brush, round brush, flat brush** — slip and underglaze painting
- **Slip trailer / bulb syringe** — raised line decoration
- **Wax resist** — masking areas before glazing

3 · Stamps and Texture Work

Stamps work best on **soft to firm plastic clay**. Press evenly and straight down — rocking the stamp creates smeared edges.

Types of stamps

- **Bisque stamps** — made from fired clay, durable and reusable. Lightly damp the stamp before pressing to prevent sticking.
- **Found objects** — bottle caps, fabric, leaves, lace, shells. Press directly into the slab before cutting your template pieces.
- **Foam/rubber stamps** — easy to find, work well for repeated patterns. Ink or slip can transfer them onto clay.

Texture rollers

Roll the textured mat across the whole slab before cutting. Cut your template pieces from the textured slab. This gives you a perfectly aligned texture without needing to match patterns across seams.

> 💡 **Tip**
> If the texture sticks to the slab when you try to lift the roller, the clay is too soft. Let it firm up for 10–15 minutes and try again.

4 · Sponge Decoration

Natural sea sponges create a mottled, organic texture. They are most useful at two stages:

- **On plastic clay** — press a damp sponge to create surface texture before firing.
- **On bisqueware** — dab underglaze or glaze with a sponge to create layered, non-uniform color.

Sponging technique

1. Wring the sponge so it is barely damp, not wet.
2. Load it lightly with underglaze or diluted slip.
3. Dab — do not wipe — in overlapping irregular blotches.
4. Allow to dry slightly, then apply a second color the same way.

> 💡 **Tip**
>
> Two contrasting colors sponged over each other give a stone or mineral effect that works especially well on plates and serving boards.

5 · Carving and Piercing (Openwork)

Work at **leather-hard** stage. The clay should feel like cold butter — firm enough to hold a clean edge, soft enough that carving does not crack the piece.

Carving

- Use a loop tool for removing larger areas; a needle tool or sgraffito tool for fine lines.
- Carve away from yourself, working in one direction to avoid tearing.
- Go in two or three shallow passes rather than one deep cut.
- Brush away clay dust as you work — it can smear back into the carved groove.

Piercing (lattice/openwork)

- Mark the pattern lightly with a needle tool before cutting.
- Use a drill bit by hand, or a sharp pointed tool, to push cleanly through the clay wall.
- Support the inside of the wall with your fingers while piercing to prevent collapse.
- Clean the pierced holes with a damp brush after they dry slightly.

> ⚠️ **Warning**
>
> Do not carve bone-dry clay — it will crack. If you missed the leather-hard window, lightly re-dampen the surface with a damp cloth, wrap in plastic for 30 minutes, and try again.

6 · Sgraffito

Sgraffito (Italian: "scratched") means applying a coat of slip or underglaze, letting it dry to leather-hard, then scratching through to reveal the clay body underneath.

Basic sgraffito steps

1. Build the piece and let it reach soft leather-hard.
2. Apply a coat of **contrasting slip or underglaze** with a fan brush. Let it go matte but not fully dry (10–20 minutes).
3. Scratch your design through the slip with a needle or sgraffito tool. The clay color underneath shows as your line.
4. Brush away loose slip gently with a dry soft brush.
5. Apply a clear or satin glaze over the whole piece before firing.

> 💡 **Tip**
>
> Dark slip on light clay gives high contrast. Light slip on dark clay (terracotta or dark stoneware) gives a softer, more subtle effect.

Design tips

- Simple geometric patterns and botanical motifs (leaves, ferns, flowers) work very well for beginners.
- Transfer designs by tracing on tracing paper, placing it on the clay, and going over the lines with a stylus — this leaves a faint impression to follow.
- Practice on test tiles before committing to a finished piece.

7 · Slip Trailing and Slip Painting

Slip trailing (raised lines)

Fill a slip trailer or bulb syringe with slip the consistency of thick cream. Trail lines, dots and patterns on leather-hard clay. When fired, the lines remain slightly raised, giving a tactile texture.

- Keep consistent pressure on the trailer for even lines.
- Practice the movement in the air before touching the clay.
- If a line goes wrong, let it dry, carefully peel it away, and smooth the surface with a damp finger before retrying.

Slip painting

Apply different colored slips with a brush on plastic or early leather-hard clay. Blend slips while still wet for soft transitions; layer when drier for defined edges.

> ⭐ **Important**
>
> Slip must match the shrinkage rate of your clay body. A commercial colored slip for your clay type is the safest option. Mismatched shrinkage causes the slip to crack or peel during drying.

8 · Decorating on a Template Piece

Because your pieces are built with measured templates, you can plan decorative elements precisely before you start.

Workflow for a decorated mug

1. Roll the slab. Apply any roller texture or stamp impressions now (plastic clay).
2. Cut the wall using the template.
3. Curl the wall and join the seam. Set on the bottom. Let reach leather-hard.
4. Apply slip or underglaze for sgraffito or slip painting.

5. Carve or scratch the design.
6. Attach the handle (leather-hard to leather-hard, scored and slipped).
7. Dry slowly covered with light plastic so the handle does not dry faster than the body and crack.

9 · Common Errors and Fixes

Problem	Likely cause	Fix
Carved edges crumble	Clay too dry	Re-dampen with a damp cloth, rewrap 30 min, retry
Stamps leave a blurred impression	Clay too soft or stamp pressed unevenly	Let clay firm up; press straight down, no rocking
Slip peels off after drying	Slip shrinkage mismatch, or applied on dry clay	Use a commercially matched slip; apply at soft leather-hard
Sgraffito lines look rough/torn	Tool dragged instead of scored	Use a sharper tool; pull toward you in smooth strokes
Slip-trailed lines spread or flatten	Slip too thin	Thicken slip; let surface firm slightly before trailing
Texture disappears after glaze firing	Thick glaze fills the texture	Use a thinner clear glaze, or leave textured areas unglazed

Quick checklist before you start decorating

- Is the clay at the right state for the technique I want to use?
- Have I assembled the piece fully (walls, bottom, any coils) before decorating?
- Are my tools clean and ready?
- Do I have a test tile to practice on first?
- Have I planned where the decoration goes relative to the handles and seams?

Next step: Glazes Guide — types, preparation and application for ceramic glazes. You will find it in your bonus guides folder.